of the rainfall normally observed in the month, affecting areas in central and Caribbean Honduras, while in Nicaragua, rainfall did not exceed 25 percent in the departments of León and Managua. High temperatures have reduced soil moisture for crops and reduced river flows and water availability in wells.

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In Honduras, according to an analysis by the National Center for Atmospheric, Oceanographic and Seismic Studies (CENAOS), a considerable reduction in rainfall was expected in July and August, mainly in the Dry Corridor, where according to weather forecasts, the *canícula* would begin in mid-July and end in early September. It was expected to be more intense than in previous years, with the damage caused by it starting to become evident.

In El Salvador, according to the Ministry of Environment and Natural Resources, four consecutive dry days have been recorded in much of the country since August 9, indicating that if this deficit continues – particularly in the eastern zone – it will become a moderate meteorological drought. In mid-August, soil moisture conditions were considered to be "adequate" throughout the country, and according to projections for the next 10 days, slight excess moisture will be recorded.

Regional production and sale of basic grains: *Primera* harvest: Preliminary field reports indicate that the basic grain production areas in the Dry Corridor of Honduras (El Paraíso, Choluteca, Valle, Francisco Morazán) and Nicaragua (Nueva Segovia, Madriz, Estelí, Matagalpa, Managua) have again reported significant damage to the *Primera* basic grain crop harvests. Damage to the harvest is estimated to be above 50 percent, mainly affecting subsistence agricultural production areas, although some commercial production areas could also be affected. This situation is jeopardizing the livestock production of the countries in the region, particularly cattle, due to poor provision of grassy pastures and fodder on farms, as well as restricted access to water.

A field visit to basic grain production areas in El Salvador carried out by FEWS NET, the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) in the first two weeks of August confirmed that *Primera* crops show no signs of being significantly damaged by rainfall irregularities, estimating that production will be average. However, in some communities in the department of La Unión, where considerable drought damage was observed, 30–50 percent of the harvest could be affected by the drought.

Postrera planting: Reports indicate that *Postrera* planting has already begun in some production areas of the region. Some areas observe traditional farming methods, while others using planting techniques recommended by